

25 Games To Play Before You Die

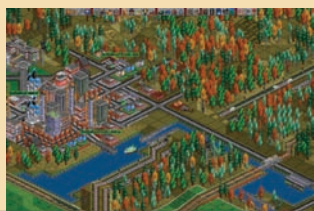
A roundup of the best...

Badri Narayan
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

25 Transport Tycoon

Years: 1994-1996

This DOS-based series lets you imagine yourself as a shrewd businessman with a fleet of transport vehicles and a willingness to outsmart the opposition at all costs. A huge game world, varied terrain, and infinite replayability are its biggest strengths.



21 Half-Life

Years: 1998-2008

Half-Life changed people's expectations of the FPS genre. It helped bring about the FPS domination still continues. HL2 was an extremely polished product with a few innovations of its own. This is one of the most recognized franchises, Halo notwithstanding.



17 Command & Conquer

Years: 1995-2010

The RTS world broadly comprises C&C and Warcraft. We've played all three WC games, but they're nowhere near the former. Any game that lets you blow up the White House and has exploding cows in it gets our vote.



13 Metal Gear

Years: 1987-2010

Fantastic production quality, a "cinematic" storyline, and challenging stealth gameplay make for a formidable combination, never mind the weird choice of names.



24 Worms

Years: 1995-2010

When one gamer says to another, "I've got worms", he isn't talking about gastrointestinal disorders. This turn-based squad combat tactical series has delighted fans for years now, and will hopefully continue to do so.



20 System Shock

Years: 1994-1999

Created by the hugely talented folks at Looking Glass (creators of the Thief series), this game practically invented the FPS/RPG hybrid on the PC. Eerily atmospheric and genuinely scary, this series inspired games such as Deus Ex and BioShock.



16 Commandos

Years: 1998-2010

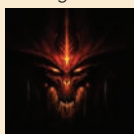
Granted, Commandos' difficulty could be frustrating at times, but the satisfaction of a hard-earned victory after hours of patience was unmatched. We look forward to the day when this franchise will be resurrected in its original avatar. Until then, clones like Pathway to Glory will have to suffice.



12 Diablo

Years: 1997-2003

Diablo is a strange entrant into this list. Hack-and-slash RPGs were around long before it appeared. The gameplay was as mindless as could be. Yet, it brought all aspects of this genre together and polished them to perfection. The result – an affair that launched a hundred clones.



23 The Elder Scrolls

Years: 1994-2007

The Elder Scrolls world didn't make an impression with its first or second iteration, but Morrowind changed the game with its huge world and massive storyline. Other fantasy RPG franchises are similarly epic in scope, but lack the polish that TES displays.



19 StarCraft

Years: 1998-2010

This game needs no introduction. Suffice it to say that this slot was a toss-up between StarCraft and Warcraft, but the former won because of its better single-player campaign and engrossing storyline. Another contender for this position was Warhammer 40,000: Dawn of War, but it lost out to the former's production quality.



15 Grand Theft Auto

Years: 1997-2009

The GTA franchise is a rare gem that has consistently upped the ante with each release, wherein the deviants at Rockstar come up with a more awesome adventure to shake you up. Praising it any more would sound trite, so all we'll say is, "More hot coffee please!". Greets also go out to Mafia. Thug life!



22 Final Fantasy

Years: 1987-2010

The first name that comes to mind when you say "Jap RPG" is Final Fantasy. Longest-running, record-breaking, prolific, and cultural phenomenon are some of the many adjectives used to describe this venerable console franchise, which has truly defined the RPG genre.



18 Burnout

Years: 2001-2009

Burnout epitomizes arcade racing frenzy, perfected in Burnout Revenge. For the joy it provides in crashing opponents' cars any number of ways, this series pips the more popular Need for Speed to the post.



14 Max Payne

Years: 2001-2008

This is the action marque that first introduced the concept of slow-motion action, and gamers were suitably blown away. The addition of a hackneyed love story didn't hurt either, because we're suckers for those things.



11 DOOM

Years: 1993-2010

There are all other FPS games, and then there is DOOM. It was the game that invented multiplayer deathmatch. The first "2.5D" game, which ushered in the shift to 3D. Its graphics were a generational leap forward.

